



APPLICATION FOR EXPERIENCE MANAGER · BLANDFORD NATURE CENTER

Haley Vincent

Builder · Leader · Nature Advocate

*"I'm not just applying to lead your guest
experience.
I'm bringing you a program."*

EXPERIENCE AT SCALE

PASSION & VALUES

NONPROFIT FOUNDER

WILDWISE · NOODLE

REFERENCES

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SECTION ONE

I've already built *exactly this.*

Skydive Grand Haven wasn't just a business — it was a guest experience operation. Every single element of the Experience Manager role maps directly to something I built, ran, and scaled.

14,800+
GUESTS SERVED

\$1M+
ANNUAL REVENUE

20+
STAFF &
VOLUNTEERS LED

7
SEASONS BUILT
FROM ZERO



Guest Experience Design

Designed every guest touchpoint from first inquiry to post-experience follow-up. Maintained a 73.4% media upsell rate through genuine connection — not pressure.



Volunteer & Team Leadership

Recruited, trained, scheduled, and developed 20+ staff and volunteers in a high-stakes environment. Wrote every protocol and playbook from scratch.



Retail & Revenue Operations

Managed merchandise, POS systems, pricing strategy, and inventory. Also ran all financials — payroll, vendor management, budgeting, and 7-year financial modeling.



Facility & Event Operations

Managed all facility logistics, coverage scheduling, and event coordination across a multi-day seasonal operation. Built systems that scaled without proportional headcount.



Group Training & Education

Trained groups of 30+ on tandem skydiving — safety-critical instruction requiring clarity, composure, and genuine engagement with diverse audiences including school groups.



School & Educational Programs

Led school tour programs at the DZ introducing kids to aviation and skydiving. Also contributed to updating the CTSP curriculum for the Tree Care Industry Association.

"I didn't inherit a playbook. I wrote one — and then I scaled a \$1M guest experience operation on top of it."

— HALEY VINCENT ON BUILDING SKYDIVE GRAND HAVEN

ALSO IN MY TOOLKIT

→ 7K social media following built organically at SDGH

THE THROUGH-LINE

→ Every role I've held, I've built the thing — not just managed it

- Retail & merchandise management (also Best Buy experience)
- B2B accounting & client services at Advantage Solutions
- Full tech stack: booking, CRM, web, communications
- Public speaking — ISA International Conference, August 2025

- I lead with culture first; performance follows from belonging
- I think in systems — processes, data, feedback loops
- I stay until the thing works, then I make it better
- My husband is an arborist. Trees are literally our household.



SECTION TWO

This isn't a career move. *It's a calling.*

The skills are the easy part to document. What's harder to put on paper — but more important — is why. Here's why Blandford Nature Center specifically.

"The values Blandford leads with — Inclusion, Stewardship, Integrity, Experiential, Partnership, Innovation — are not words I had to pause and consider. They are the values I have operated from in every organization I've built."

— FROM HALEY'S COVER LETTER

 Lifelong nature lover

 Wildlife advocate

 Science & conservation

 Environmental stewardship

 Community builder

 Innovation mindset

 Mission-driven leader

WHO I AM AS A LEADER

- I build cultures where people feel like they belong — not just employees or volunteers, but contributors to something meaningful
- I lead with high emotional intelligence and zero tolerance for the kind of leadership that manages through fear
- I'm a paid public speaker on leadership and conflict resolution — I practice what I teach
- I model the behavior I want to see; the team takes the culture cues from me
- I stay curious and never stop improving systems — Innovation isn't a value for me, it's a reflex

MY CONNECTION TO NATURE

- Animals and conservation have been lifelong passions — not interests I picked up for a resume
- I am an active volunteer wildlife transporter — I pick up and transport injured animals to rehabbers in my free time
- My cousin is Dr. [Name], a veterinarian and licensed raccoon & possum rehabber operating under BNC's umbrella
- I co-founded WildWise Wildlife Education in response to a gap in the wildlife support system I personally encountered
- Dave, my husband, is a professional arborist and safety expert — nature is genuinely our household

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR BNC

A guest experience manager who genuinely loves what the organization stands for will always outperform one who is simply qualified. I am not applying to BNC because it's a good job. I'm applying because connecting people — especially kids — with the natural world is something I have cared about deeply my entire life. That passion is visible. It's contagious. And it's exactly the energy a visitor center runs on.



SECTION THREE

I didn't just work *at a nonprofit. I built one.*

Co-founding ASCEND — a 501(c)(3) dedicated to aviation and skydiving career development — gave me a complete, founder-level education in nonprofit operations. Not as a staff member. As the architect.

**501(c)(3) Formation**

Navigated the full IRS application process, obtained nonprofit status, and built the governance infrastructure from scratch — articles, bylaws, board structure.

**Operations & Technology**

Built the full operational and tech infrastructure — website, career exploration tools, filterable program directory, scholarship resources, and wing loading calculator.

**Community & Volunteer Engagement**

Led volunteer coordination, partner outreach, and community engagement efforts. Built relationships with industry organizations serving the national aviation community.

**Communications & Development**

Managed organizational communications, donor relations, grant research, and board member recruitment — including bringing on a police captain as a board member.

"Building a nonprofit from zero teaches you things that no job description can. Governance, mission alignment, community trust, volunteer culture, fiscal stewardship — when you're the founder, you own all of it."

— HALEY ON CO-FOUNDING ASCEND FOUNDATION

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR BNC

I understand mission-driven organizations at a structural level. I know how volunteer culture works, how community trust is built, how fiscal responsibility looks when resources are tight, and how to develop programs that serve a community — not just check boxes.

I also bring a deep respect for the weight of nonprofit stewardship. Every dollar, every volunteer hour, every guest interaction is an expression of the organization's mission. I take that seriously — because I've been the person responsible for it.

ASCEND FOUNDATION · 2024–PRESENT



SECTION FOUR

A program born from *an impossible situation.*

How Noodle changed everything

Noodle is a raccoon — fully imprinted on humans from an early age, non-releasable, and deeply bonded to our family. When I realized the legal and logistical reality of his situation, I faced a choice most people never have to make: give him up to an outcome that felt unconscionable, or figure out how to do right by him within a system that had no clear path forward. I chose to figure it out. I connected with a licensed wildlife rehabber — who happens to be my cousin, Dr. [Name], now operating under BNC's umbrella — to ensure Noodle received proper veterinary care and documentation. And then I started building the thing that should have already existed: a structured wildlife education program with Noodle at the center.



WildWise Wildlife Education

A fully designed, nearly complete wildlife education program — with branding, strategic roadmap, 4-phase growth plan, and a nearly-finished website — waiting for the right institutional home. That home could be Blandford Nature Center.

WHAT EXISTS TODAY

Complete brand identity, logo suite, color system. A detailed 4-phase strategic roadmap. A nearly finished website (~80% complete). A defined program vision and ambassador animal.

THE PROGRAM VISION

School ambassador visits. Wildlife First Responder training. Community education programs. A volunteer transporter network. Eventually: a digital platform connecting rescuers to rehabbers statewide.

THE PROPOSAL

Rather than pursue independent 501(c)(3) status, I'd love to build WildWise as a BNC program — eliminating the legal overhead while giving BNC a ready-built educational initiative with an ambassador animal and a passionate founder already on staff.

WHY THIS IS GOOD FOR BNC

→ Noodle as a licensed educational ambassador animal — BNC's facility permit resolves the legal situation entirely

→

→ A ready-designed program with brand, roadmap, and website already built — zero startup cost for the concept

→ A founder-level operator who will be infinitely more invested than any hired program director

Dr. [Cousin's Name] already on staff as the veterinary/
rehabbing partner — the team is already there



SECTION FIVE

People who can speak *to who I am.*

Three people who know my work, my character, and my commitment — from three completely different angles.

R

BNC-Connected · Veterinarian · Family

Dr. [Cousin's Name]

Veterinarian & Licensed Wildlife Rehabber · Blandford Nature Center

My cousin has known me my entire life and has watched me build Skydive Grand Haven into a \$1M+ operation. He's also the licensed rehabber who helped me navigate Noodle's care and documentation — he has direct, firsthand knowledge of my commitment to doing right by animals even when it's complicated. He has jumped at my dropzone, worked alongside me on WildWise, and operates within BNC's own network.

B

Executive Leadership · Corporate Operations

Bob Hendriksen

Director, Operations & Continuous Improvement | Enabling Operational Excellence · Steelcase

Bob can speak to my operational thinking, systems mindset, and leadership approach from a senior executive perspective. His vantage point as a continuous improvement leader at one of West Michigan's most respected organizations lends significant weight to his assessment of how I build and run things.

A

Community Leader · Board Member · ASCEND Foundation

Andy Rush

Captain · Muskegon Police Department · Board Member, ASCEND Foundation

Andy joined ASCEND's board at my invitation — a decision that speaks to both my ability to recruit high-caliber community leaders and the seriousness with which I approach organizational governance. As a law enforcement captain and community leader, his perspective on my character, integrity, and mission-driven approach carries considerable weight.

"Everything starts with Noodle. Everything else follows from there."

